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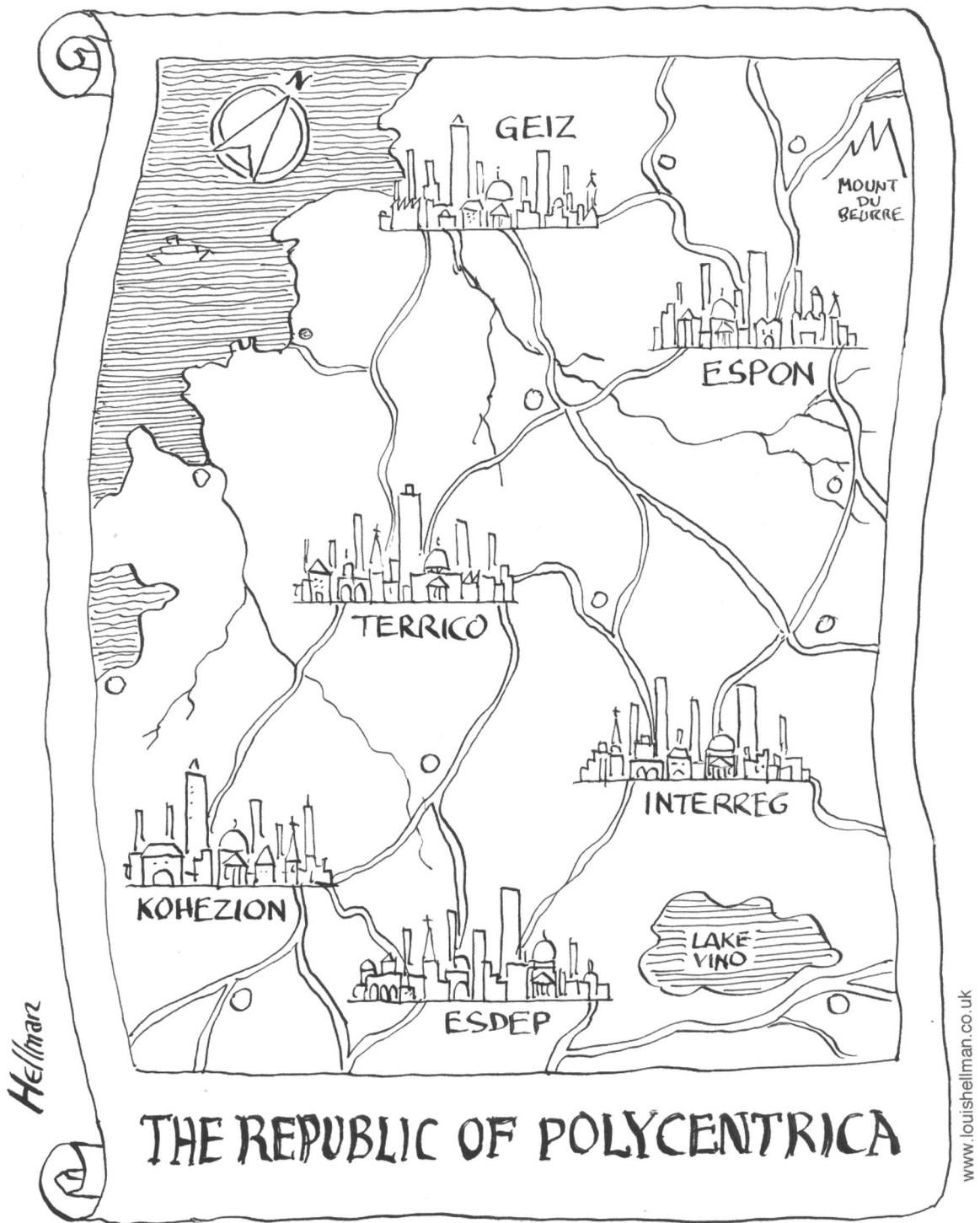
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Polycentric Development Policies in European Countries: An Introduction

EVERT MEIJERS, BAS WATERHOUT and WIL ZONNEVELD

The concept of polycentricity is one of the cornerstones of the European Spatial Development Perspective (ESDP), the first EU policy document on territorial government, albeit informal and non-binding, agreed upon by the EU's 15 ministers responsible for spatial planning and the European Commission (CEC, 1999). Polycentricity was the outcome of a long debate during the ESDP process between representatives of the Member States and the European Commission. This debate can be characterized by give-and-take and finding compromises and consensus (Faludi and Waterhout, 2002). From a substantive point of view its most important feature is that it links the seemingly conflicting goals of cohesion across the EU territory and the level of competitiveness of the EU on the global level (Zonneveld, 2000; Waterhout, 2002). The ESDP itself provides only a superficial elaboration of the concept of polycentricity. The main idea is to promote the development of so-called 'Global Economic Integration Zones' throughout Europe, primarily on the basis of their own endogenous potential. Global Economic Integration Zones are areas participating fully in the global economy. The general way of looking at the EU territory is that it is characterized by just one area meeting the criteria related to the status of a Global Economic Integration Zone while the United States hosts at least three zones like this. In Europe it is located between London, Paris, Milan, Munich and Hamburg and hence is called the 'pentagon'. For the EU 15 it is

calculated that in this pentagon 50 per cent of EU GDP is produced by 40 per cent of the EU inhabitants in 20 per cent of the EU territory. The ESDP does not say much about the locations of possible new global integration zones and considers this a subject for further debate, a debate that indeed has taken place since then (see for instance CPMR, 2002).

Polycentricity: Getting Rid of the Core-Periphery Model

The polycentricity concept marks a paradigm change in thinking about Europe's spatial and economic structure. It replaces the core-periphery model suggested by the so-called Blue Banana (Brunet, 1989), which was often put forward in the first years (roughly 1989–1991) of co-operation between the EC Member States and the Commission (the follow-up report to Brunet's study no longer distinguishes a European core in this way; see Rozenblat and Cicille, 2003). Instead, the ESDP advocates the creation of several 'dynamic zones of global economic integration, well distributed throughout the EU territory and comprising a network of internationally accessible metropolitan regions and their hinterland (towns, cities and rural areas of varying sizes)'. The ESDP continues by saying that this polycentric development should not remain restricted to Europe's larger metropolitan areas because this would not be '... in line with the tradition of maintaining the urban and rural diversity of the EU' (CEC, 1999, para.

70, 71). The guiding principle here is the concept of city hierarchies: a polycentric settlement structure has to cut across the whole of the EU territory. Each new Global Economic Integration Zone contributes to a polycentric development of the European territory as a whole, while each zone itself exhibits a polycentric urban structure. We can therefore say that the ESDP embraces a *nested* polycentricity concept. Every centre (even though the ESDP does not give an indication of the size of a 'centre') is seen as a polycentric system.

It is at this precise point that the polycentricity concept spills over to include urban-rural partnerships through the statement that cities have increasingly diverse functional inter-dependencies with their surrounding countryside, and that these 'inter-dependencies require voluntary co-operation' (CEC, 1999, para. 75; see Bengs and Zonneveld, 2002, p. 283). At this point the ESDP not only addresses urbanized regions, but also less densely settled and economically weaker regions. Here the ESDP advocates the creation of networks of smaller towns because co-operation between urban centres to develop functional complementarities may form the only possible route for achieving viable markets and maintaining economic institutions and services, something which could not – according to the ESDP – be achieved by towns on their own. This is just one of the many manifestations of partnerships within the ESDP. Be that as it may, any discussion on the application of the concept of polycentricity has to take into account that the concept can be applied to various levels of scale: the pan-European scale, the EU-scale, transnational scale and, finally, national and sub-national scales. The national scale is the focus of interest of this issue of *Built Environment*.

At the European scale, after its publication in the ESDP, the concept of polycentricity has reappeared on several occasions. The most important is the Second Cohesion Report (CEC, 2001). Cohesion reports are politically

highly influential. They shed light on the effectiveness of one of the largest budgets within the EU and as such play a major role in discussions in the European Parliament and the Committee of the Regions on these budgets: the structural and cohesion funds. In the cohesion reports the Commission normally proposes changes in the existing funds which stirs up political debate. All in all these reports should also be carefully read within the spatial planning community.

In the Second Cohesion Report the European Commission emphasizes that cities are a key location for the pursuit of any strategy for cohesion and sustainable development and that networks of large cities can stimulate a more balanced and polycentric form of development in Europe (CEC, 2001).

In the Third Cohesion Report (CEC, 2004) the concept of polycentricity is not mentioned. Instead territorial cohesion is the focus. Although it is not yet certain whether the Constitutional Treaty will be ratified by all EU member states this treaty declares territorial cohesion as one of the goals of the Union, next to social and economic cohesion. In the Third Cohesion Report the Commission clearly anticipates this and emphasizes that in future the structure funds will have to acquire a more explicit territorial orientation. This is already reflected in the proposal to promote co-operation between regions and countries in the domain of spatial development as one of the three main future objectives of the structure funds. At present this form of co-operation takes place in the context of the Community Initiative INTERREG IIIB and IIIC.

We would like to accept Andreas Faludi's expectation, namely that polycentricity is likely to become an issue in EU territorial cohesion policy (Faludi, 2005). In that case we are dealing here with an important policy concept. Seen from this point of view it is imperative to determine whether future EU policy orientation fits in well with national policies oriented towards territorial cohesion.

Polycentric Development at the National Scale

Returning to the structure of the polycentricity concept we can see not only the application of polycentricity to several spatial scales, but also that the *meaning* of polycentricity varies among these scales (see for instance Davoudi, 2003). At the lower scales of cities and urban regions, Davoudi (2003) considers the polycentricity concept mainly as an analytical tool, whereas at the European level it is used mainly as the expression of a normative agenda. At the national scale, it is most likely that both meanings are significant. Polycentricity can be a feature of the national urban system, depending on the shape of the urban hierarchy. At the same time it reflects a normative position as is witnessed by the fact that a major objective of national territorial development policies throughout Europe is to increase the polycentricity of the urban system. These interpretations do not seem to be in conflict *a priori*.

What Davoudi labels as 'the normative agenda' stands central in this special issue. In other words, we focus on development policies that try to bring about a polycentric urban structure, the normative standpoint being that this would be beneficial in some respect. It will be shown that there is considerable variation between countries regarding the objectives, instruments and embeddedness of polycentric development policies. This would indicate that the meaning of polycentricity not only differs between spatial scales, but even at the same – national – scale. Nevertheless, there are also many similarities, as all the different approaches comply with the defining characteristics of a polycentric development policy. Given that, basically, 'polycentric' denotes the existence of multiple centres in a given area, we define a polycentric development policy as one *that addresses the distribution of economic and/or economically relevant functions over the urban system in such a way that a multitude of urban centres rather than one or two gains significance.*

Clearly, with a European territorial cohesion policy in the offing (Faludi, 2004; Zonneveld and Waterhout, 2005) it makes sense to find out what member states themselves are actually doing in the field of polycentric development. With, potentially, an emphasis on, amongst others, polycentric development, the formulation of a European territorial cohesion policy can benefit from national experiences with polycentric development policies. Any future territorial cohesion policy, including the strategy to aim for a polycentric development of the European territory, cannot follow generic policy principles. Territorial diversity across Europe is extremely wide, and national urban systems in particular differ greatly. Seen from this viewpoint national experiences may contribute to the drafting of EU policies. Although the concept of polycentric development might be relatively new at the European level, similar concepts, be it under this or other labels, have featured in national policies sometimes for decades (we leave the subsidiarity principle aside when emphasizing the importance of national policy orientations).

Aims and Background of this Special Issue

On the basis of territorial diversity between and within countries, national policies aiming at polycentric development may follow different approaches. To make things more complex, the very concept of polycentricity may have different meanings in different countries. Depending on, for instance, the national territorial and urban structure, the concept of polycentricity may refer to a wide variety of policy problems and objectives. Conversely, we may also find similarities between approaches in different countries. This then could be interpreted as the possible existence of universal elements in polycentric development policies. To our mind, such knowledge could be helpful in designing a polycentric policy at the European level. Consequently, the aim of this Special Issue

is to develop a wider appreciation and understanding of the variety and similarities between different national approaches to polycentric development in Europe.

This special issue of *Built Environment* can be regarded as the offspring of a research project called 'The role, specific situation and potentials of urban areas as nodes in a polycentric development', which was carried out under the ESPON 2006 Programme. ESPON stands for European Spatial Planning Observation Network and is financed through INTERREG IIIB and the EU Member States. It covers twenty-nine European countries (the EU25 plus Switzerland, Norway, Romania and Bulgaria) and aspires to achieve a better understanding of spatial trends, problems and opportunities at a European scale, to monitor them using newly developed indicators and mapping techniques, and to provide tools and instruments for a better territorial governance at EU-level.

The ESPON project on polycentricity¹ itself was carried out between 2002 and 2004 by a consortium of fourteen partners, including the lead partner Nordregio based in Stockholm. Its major aims were (i) to explore the driving forces behind polycentric development, be they spatial or political; (ii) to develop measurable indicators in order to monitor territorial processes and mapping them; and (iii) to arrive at a better understanding of how governance relationships play a role in polycentric urban patterns. Together these research orientations have cumulated in a number of policy recommendations for a balanced territorial development across Europe (Nordregio *et al.*, 2004).

Within the project the editors of this special issue were responsible for a work package on 'The application of polycentricity in European countries'. In short, what we tried to find out was if and how the concept of polycentric development, be it in these or other terms, played a role in domestic policies. Obviously, the amount of time available did not provide for in-depth research. Therefore, we developed a survey based on

a questionnaire, which was issued to key persons in all twenty-nine ESPON countries. Much interesting material was gathered which resulted in a report of separate country studies and a synthesis report (Zonneveld *et al.*, 2004). However, the feeling arose that a lot of ground that could be of great interest remained unexplored. Hence, this special issue allows for more in-depth articles by predominantly national experts.

The Countries Discussed in this Special Issue

For this special issue we selected six countries that together represent most of the wide diversity of objectives and instruments and the variety in the extent of embeddedness of polycentric development policies that we found: France, Greece, Ireland, Poland, Finland and Italy. Moreover, these countries differ from each other as regards the structure of their national urban system. Ireland is an example of a country with a strongly monocentric urban structure, while the urban system in, for instance, Italy and Poland is obviously much more polycentric. In addition, these six countries present a cross-section of some of the more elaborated polycentric development policies in European countries.

Taken individually, each country discussed here also has some specific characteristics that make it particularly interesting as these together highlight the issues and debates linked to polycentric development strategies. We will turn to these issues and debates in the final contribution. The other contributions to this issue present polycentric development strategies in more detail, including, for each country, an examination of the structure of the urban system and trends in this system, the rationales for pursuing polycentricity, the instruments linked to polycentric development, and the embeddedness of such policies.

The dominance of Paris in the French national urban system has been considered

undesirable by policy-makers for more than half a century. Therefore, France is an example of a country in which polycentricity – as we call it today – is strongly embedded. Baudelle and Peyrony discuss the evolution of French polycentric development strategies. The current emphasis on providing cities with equal opportunities rather than treating them equally is explained by considerations of economic efficiency and social justice.

Greece is another example of a country with a long-standing tradition of polycentric development policies. The dominance of Athens has been addressed by a number of successive policies since the 1960s. Angelidis presents these policies and discusses how they have been adapted to the changing social, economic and administrative context.

Having established a strong economic performance as a nation, the attention of Irish policy-makers has turned to how that performance is maintained and geographically distributed within the country in a more balanced manner. Balanced regional development has become the fundamental principle of the national spatial strategy. Davoudi and Wishardt discuss the strengths and weaknesses of this ambitious strategy.

Poland's urban system is already relatively polycentric. This polycentricity is seen as an important asset and policies try to sustain it. However, being a transition country, Poland is currently facing the fact that urban growth takes place selectively, so some cities are developing and prospering, whereas others are relatively declining. Though this favours the competitiveness of some of the larger cities, it also leads to increasing polarization in the urban system. Korcelli addresses the Polish approach to the dilemma, often labelled as competitiveness versus cohesion.

In Finland, polycentric development policies take the form of urban policy programmes as Antikainen and Vartiainen explain. Interestingly, these programmes are based on clear ideas of how polycentricity could be achieved. In the Finnish approach towards a polycentric development of the

national territory much emphasis is put on 'soft' instruments like the encouragement of innovative capacity and the establishment of regional networks between relevant stakeholders.

The polycentric urban structure in Italy represents both the historical and cultural specificity of the country, although, as is well-known, there is a wide development gap between north and south. One could argue, as Salone does, that polycentric development is also at the heart of national politics. Interestingly, without a planning competency at the national level, this focus comes about in a rather implicit way through various sector policies that individually take the development of middle-sized cities as their starting point. In the northern part of Italy these policies help to sustain the polycentric pattern, while in the southern part the effects seem less successful.

In summary, this special issue reveals some of the variety in current policies aimed at polycentric urban development at national and regional levels. There are certain commonalities though. The final paper by Waterhout, Zonneveld and Meijers reviews and compares national polycentric development policies, covering the entire ESPON study area and therefore also discussing countries not treated individually in this special issue. This final article presents general findings on the objectives, the instrumental equipment and working practices, and embeddedness of polycentric development policies in general. Moreover, it highlights some prominent issues, debates and dilemmas faced when developing polycentric development strategies at the national and also European level.

NOTE

1. In the ESPON programme all projects have a numeric code. The project on polycentricity bears the code 1.1.1. and falls within the class of thematic studies. For a further look into the project's details and the ESPON programme in general please consult: www.espon.lu.

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